

BRIJMOHAN AGARWAL, *64*

| BJP | *Raipur, Chhattisgarh*

As a 2023 victor from Raipur—his eighth straight assembly win since 1990—and having taken oath again as minister, his candidacy was a surprise. A veteran of many Raman Singh cabinets, his supporters lament that his exclusion from the Union cabinet too is a surprise.



DULU MAHTO, *49*

| BJP | *Dhanbad, Jharkhand*

When the BJP opted to move the three-time MLA from Baghmara—in the Giridih LS constituency next door—right into the heart of coal, it raised eyebrows as it had to unseat three-time MP Pashupati Nath Singh. The future MP had a bit of history too: Dulu has been convicted in two criminal cases—one involving an attack on the police; the other an excise team. He was eligible only because he got less than two years' jail in both cases. Dulu has challenged both verdicts in the Jharkhand HC... the other 20 cases can presumably wait.



SHIVMANGAL S. TOMAR, *60*

| BJP | *Morena, MP*

This farmer's son, deemed close to ex-Union minister Narendra Singh Tomar, was seen as a shoo-in for another stint as Dimani MLA, but his mentor was dispatched there in 2023. He got the return gift, though, in another 'switch hit' by the BJP.



BHARAT SINGH KUSHWAHA, *54*

| BJP | *Gwalior, MP*

A minister in the Shivraj Chouhan cabinet (2020-23), this ex-Gwalior Rural MLA was a surprise pick ahead of Jyotiraditya Scindia—especially since he'd lost in 2023. Being a 'Narendra Tomar man' in the Gwalior-Chambal belt has its perks.



BHAJAN LAL JATAV, *55*

| CONGRESS | *Karauli-Dholpur (SC), Rajasthan*

Twice MLA from Weir, and even MoS (home) and PWD minister in the Ashok Gehlot ministry after 2018, he'd come third in the party's 2023 assembly poll washout but has since got it back with interest.



ATUL GARG, *66*

| BJP | *Ghaziabad, UP*

The son of Ghaziabad's first mayor D.C. Garg, who got to be an MoS in Yogi Adityanath's first ministry, is a chip off the old Vaishya block, with strong associations in the education industry.



CHHATRAPAL SINGH GANGWAR, *68*

| BJP | *Bareilly, UP*

The lifelong RSS man and ex-MLA became the Gangwar to replace another Gangwar—former Union minister Santosh Gangwar. The near-continuous Bareilly MP since 1989 fades into the septuagenarian sunset.

—Prashant Srivastava, Ajay Sukumaran, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Amarnath K. Menon, Kaushik Deka, Rahul Noronha, Jeemon Jacob, Rohit Parihar and Amitabh Srivastava